

The Seven

Seven everyday things you quietly overpay for — and the simple way to make or replace each one.

You watched the 60 seconds. Here is the whole thing. Independence is not dramatic. It is a hundred small things you stopped having to buy. Here are seven of the easiest to take back — each one cheaper, simpler, and often better than the store version.

SEVEN TO TAKE BACK

- **All-purpose cleaner** — half water, half white vinegar in a spray bottle, with a drop of dish soap for grease. Pennies a bottle, no fumes.
- **Drain freshener** — baking soda followed by hot water, once a week, instead of pricey drain products.
- **Bread** — flour, water, salt, yeast, and time make a better loaf than the bagged stuff for a fraction of the price.
- **Stock and broth** — simmer the vegetable scraps and bones you would have thrown away into a richer stock than any carton.
- **Salad dressing** — oil, vinegar or lemon, salt, and a little mustard, shaken in a jar. Thirty seconds, no preservatives.
- **Coffee** — a bag of beans and a simple brewer pays for itself against the daily café cup inside a week.
- **Rags** — cut worn-out shirts and towels into cleaning rags instead of buying paper. Wash and reuse them for years.

WHY IT ADDS UP

- **You stop paying for packaging and marketing** — most of the price of these things is the bottle and the brand, not what is inside.
 - **You control what goes in** — fewer additives, fresher results, your own standard.
 - **The skill compounds** — every thing you can make yourself is one less thing that can run out at the worst possible moment.
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KEEP THIS IN MIND

Do not try all seven at once. Pick the one you buy most often, replace it this week, and let it become habit. Independence is built one quiet substitution at a time.

A hundred small things you stopped having to buy — that is what a free man's house is actually made of. Start with one. — The Sage

SOURCES University cooperative extension, home & family resources · Consumer Reports · USDA, home food basics

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